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CODEX OF THE SELF

*A manual of inner observation: divided attention, the
three centres and the work of being present*

VILLUMINATIONS

Fine edition, 2026

Original work · First edition, 2026

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ABOUT THIS WORK

Codex of the Self is an original work by Villuminations, written and typeset entirely for **villuminations.com**. Original work · First edition, 2026.

The material it starts from belongs to the **common tradition**: the classical exercises of examination of conscience, attention and inner record-keeping have been transmitted in writing for centuries and are nobody's property. What is offered here —the writing, the chapter structure, the practices, the entries and the illustrations— is original work and is protected as such.

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CHAPTER 1

YOU WERE NOT HERE

Try something before reading on. Close the book and try to remember how you got to this page: what position you were in two minutes ago, what your breathing was doing, what you were thinking just before you opened it. Almost certainly you do not know.

It is not a fault of yours. It is the default mode of human functioning, and it is this book's starting point: we spend most of our lives doing things without being present while we do them. We eat while reading, we drive while thinking, we argue without hearing, and at the end of the day we could not reconstruct a tenth of what went through our heads.

WHAT THIS BOOK PROPOSES

A concrete, ancient and verifiable discipline: learning to be present in what you are doing while you do it. Not as a permanent state —that does not exist and anyone promising it is selling something— but as a trainable capacity that begins with a few seconds a day and grows with practice.

The traditional name of this discipline is self-observation. It is not introspection, and the difference matters from the first page: introspection thinks about oneself, and self-observation looks. Thinking about oneself is one more of the activities carried out while absent. Looking is something else.

WHAT IT DOES NOT PROPOSE

- It does not propose a belief. There is no cosmology here, nothing has to be accepted in advance, and everything asserted can be checked in your own experience within days.
- It does not propose a therapy. This book does not treat disorders, does not replace psychological care and is not the place to resolve a trauma. If you are in a crisis, what you need is a professional; you will come back to this afterwards and it will be more use to you.
- It does not promise peace. Self-observation produces, at first, a good deal of discomfort: you see what you did not see and a fair part of it is not pleasant. Anyone looking for immediate consolation will find other reading sooner.
- It does not promise spectacular results. It produces one very sober thing: more time awake inside your own life. When you try it, that turns out to be enough.

THE ONE PROMISE THIS BOOK MAKES

If you practise what is proposed here for three months, with a written record, you will know things about your own functioning that you do not know today: what sets you off, in what order you react, how long your states last and which of your opinions about yourself were false. That is all, and it is more than most people find out in a whole lifetime.

CHAPTER 2

THE FOUR THINGS WE DO NOT KNOW ABOUT OURSELVES

Before proposing a method it is worth stating the problem precisely. There are four facts about one's own functioning that almost nobody knows and that are discovered in the first weeks of observation. All four are verifiable and all four are uncomfortable.

FIRST: WE REACT BEFORE WE DECIDE

The sequence we believe happens is: something occurs, I evaluate it, I decide how to respond, I respond. The real sequence is different: something occurs, the body has already responded —the jaw, the tone of voice, the breathing— and then a story appears explaining the response as though it had been a decision. The justification always arrives after the act, and it arrives so fast that it gets mistaken for its cause.

SECOND: WE DO NOT KNOW WHAT STATE WE ARE IN

Ask someone how they are and they will answer «fine» or «tired» without having looked. It is an automatic reply, not a report. The ability to say what state you are in —precisely, with a bodily location, with a

duration— does not come as standard: it is learnt, and it is the first skill this book trains.

THIRD: WE CHANGE PERSON SEVERAL TIMES A DAY

The one who talks to their boss and the one who talks to their mother are not exactly the same: the voice changes, the vocabulary changes, the opinions change, and in some cases they contradict each other without anyone noticing. We call it adaptation and in good part it is. But anyone who observes carefully will discover that there is not one person in there adapting, but several who take turns and barely know one another.

FOURTH: WE DO NOT REMEMBER OUR OWN STATES

This is the hardest to accept and the one that makes the notebook compulsory. Memory for inner states is dreadful and it also rewrites: after three days you do not remember how you felt, and what you do remember is tinted by what has happened since. Without a written record you cannot know whether anything is changing, and therefore you cannot correct anything.



THE PRACTICAL CONSEQUENCE

These four facts define this book's method. Because we react before we decide, the pause has to be sought. Because we do not know what state we are in, we have to learn to look at it. Because we change person, we have to record which one is in charge. And because we do not remember, we have to write. Everything else is a development of those four consequences.

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Self-observation was not invented by anyone recently. It is worth knowing where the material comes from, both out of honesty and because the ancient sources are still better than almost everything published today.

THE STOICS: BETWEEN THE FIRST AND SECOND CENTURIES

The Roman Stoic school left three texts that are, in fact, practice manuals and have always been in the public domain. Epictetus, a freed slave who taught at Nicopolis, dictated a «Handbook» of forty-three short chapters whose first line contains the most useful idea in all of practical philosophy: there are things that depend on us and things that do not, and almost all avoidable suffering comes from confusing them. Marcus Aurelius, emperor, wrote over years a set of private notes he never meant to publish and which are the best surviving example of self-observation in writing. Seneca, in his letters, describes the practice of the nightly examination in a detail that still serves as instruction today.

THIS BOOK'S THREE ANCIENT SOURCES

EPICTETUS

«Handbook» (Enchiridion), first–second century. The distinction between what depends on us and what does not. Chapter 15 of this book.

MARCUS AURELIUS

«Meditations», second century. Self-observation in writing, with no audience and no ornament. Chapters 10 and 19.

SENECA

«Letters to Lucilius», first century. The examination of conscience at the end of the day, with its concrete method. Chapter 14.

THE CONTEMPLATIVE TRADITION

Techniques of sustained attention, of watchfulness over thought and of dividing attention appear independently in traditions that had no knowledge of one another: in the Christian monasticism of the early centuries, in the Buddhist schools, in Sufism, in yogic practice. That convergence is an interesting fact in itself: when people who have not read one another arrive at the same procedure, it is usually because the procedure describes something real about human functioning.

THE TWENTIETH CENTURY AND PSYCHOLOGY

Contemporary psychology has studied a good part of this territory with a different vocabulary and with experimental method: sustained attention, emotional labelling, cognitive reappraisal, psychological distance. This book does not set out that literature —it is not its format— but it does lean on it so as not to assert things that have been ruled out and not to promise effects that do not hold up.

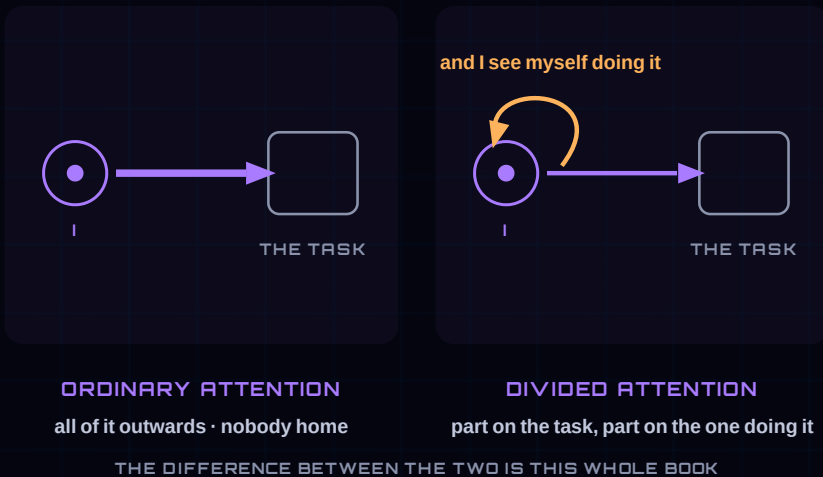
WHAT IS DISCARDED FROM THE TRADITION

A fair amount. Any hierarchy of masters and disciples is discarded, because it produces dependence. The idea that suffering is necessary for progress is discarded, because it has done a great deal of harm. The contempt for the body and the emotions that some of these schools drag along is discarded: in this book the body is the principal instrument and the emotions are information, not obstacles. And secrecy is discarded: everything here has been in print for centuries.

CHAPTER 4

DIVIDED ATTENTION

Here is the central instrument of the whole book, and it can be described in one sentence: doing something and seeing yourself do it, at the same time.



PL. 1 On the left, ordinary attention: all of it towards the object. On the right, divided attention: part stays on the task and part returns to the one doing it.

HOW ORDINARY ATTENTION WORKS

Normally attention goes entirely outwards. You look at the screen and you are in the screen; you argue and you are in the argument. Nothing is left looking inwards, and so for all that time there is nobody

recording what happens. It is exactly what being absent means: not that attention is lacking, but that all of it is spent in one place.

HOW IT IS DIVIDED

A small part —very little is enough— is reserved for the fact that there is someone doing it. It is not thinking about yourself, and this distinction is the hardest at first. It is not a matter of mentally commenting «now I am writing»; that is another thought and it consumes attention just as the first one does. It is a matter of feeling, without words, that there is a body here writing.

THE THREE THINGS IT IS NOT

IT IS NOT THINKING ABOUT YOURSELF

That is one more thought, and it goes outwards like all the rest.

IT IS NOT JUDGING WHAT YOU ARE DOING

Judgement interrupts observation: the moment you appraise, you have stopped looking.

IT IS NOT DROPPING THE TASK

The task goes on just as well, and with practice better. If the task stops, it was not divided attention: it was distraction.

THE FIRST EXERCISE

- 1 Choose an ordinary action you do every day and that lasts less than a minute: washing your hands, climbing a flight of stairs, pouring yourself water.
- 2 Each time you do it, and only then, add this: feel the weight of your body and the air going in and out, while you do it.

- 3 Do nothing else. Do not appraise it, do not prolong it, do not turn it into meditation. Ten or twenty seconds.
- 4 Count the times you forgot. That number is your real starting point and it will come down very slowly.

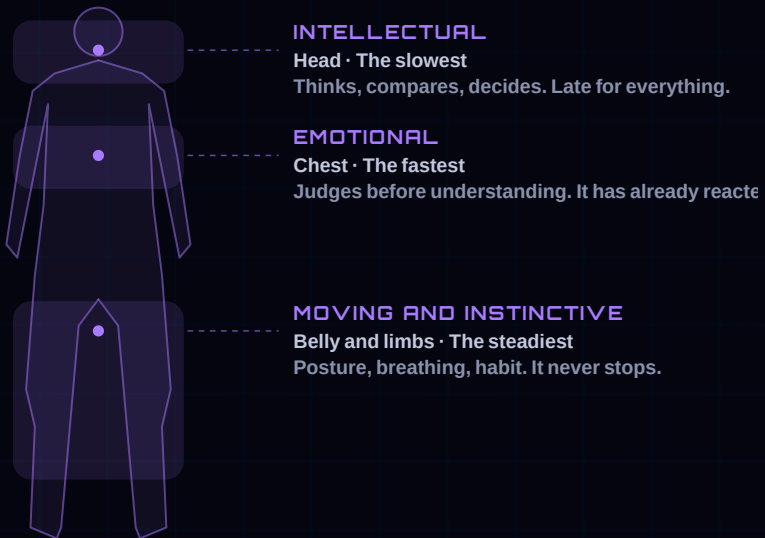
WHAT YOU ARE GOING TO DISCOVER IN THE FIRST WEEK

That you forget almost every time. That when you remember, you have already finished the action. And that the mere fact of remembering produces an abrupt and recognisable change, as if someone had switched on a light. That change is the phenomenon we are training, and the first time it is felt clearly it is hard to forget.

CHAPTER 5

THE THREE CENTRES

A very useful traditional scheme, offered here as what it is: a working model, not a neuroanatomical description. Its value lies in the fact that it orders observation.



THREE DIFFERENT SPEEDS IN THE SAME BODY

PL. 2 The three centres with their seat, their relative speed and their function. The scheme is traditional and is used here as a map for observation, not as a physiological claim.

WHY THREE

Because when you begin to observe yourself you discover that the responses do not all come from the same place or at the same speed. There is a kind of response that is an articulate thought and arrives late. There is another that is an immediate appraisal, an «I like this» or «I do not» that appears before any reasoning. And there is a third that is purely bodily: posture, muscle tone, breathing, habits of gesture, running without interruption and without anyone consulting it.

THE THREE, IN PRACTICE

INTELLECTUAL	Seat: the head. The slowest. It thinks, compares, plans, decides. It always arrives after something has happened, and almost always in order to explain it.
EMOTIONAL	Seat: the chest. The fastest. It appraises before understanding. By the time the intellectual begins to analyse, this one has already reacted and coloured everything else.
MOVING AND INSTINCTIVE	Seat: the belly and the limbs. The steadiest. Posture, breathing, movement, habit. It never stops, not even in sleep.

WHAT THE SCHEME IS FOR

For locating. When an observation cannot be placed in any of the three, it was not an observation but an idea. And when it can be placed, the information becomes far more precise: «I am nervous» says nothing; «high breathing and raised shoulders, with no particular thought» says a great deal, and it also suggests what to do.

THE RULE OF THE FASTEST

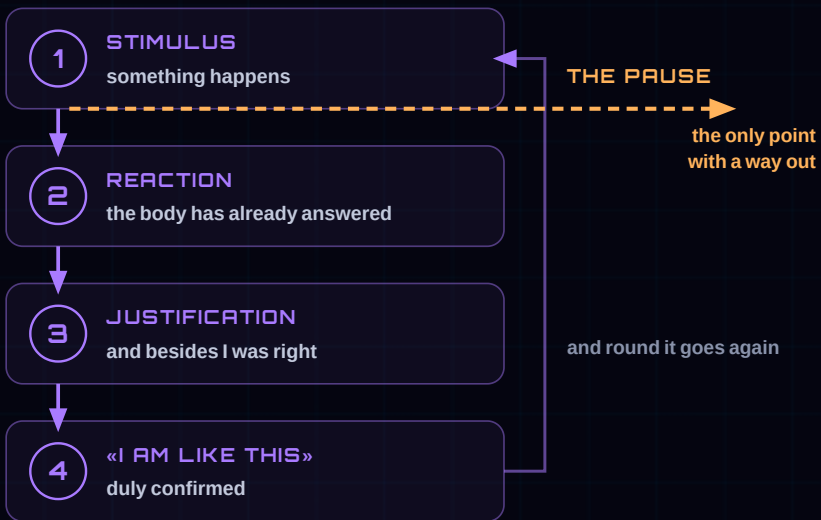
Of the three, the emotional one is what rules in practice, and not because it is more important: because it arrives first. When a strong reaction appears, the emotional centre has already decided and the intellectual one is merely drafting the report. The whole technique of the pause in the next chapter consists of inserting a few seconds between those two moments.

BEING HONEST ABOUT THIS SCHEME

The three-centre model comes from the tradition and not from neuroscience. It does not correspond to particular brain structures and it is not offered as if it did. It is kept because as a tool for classifying your own observations it works extraordinarily well: three drawers are enough to sort almost everything and few enough to be used in the heat of the moment.

THE LOOP OF IDENTIFICATION

Identifying is the traditional word for the most frequent and most costly phenomenon of the inner life: ceasing to have something and becoming it. Not having anger, but being the anger. It is the difference between «there is fear here» and «I am a coward», and that difference decides a great deal.



THE LOOP CLOSES ITSELF · THE PAUSE HAS TO BE PUT THERE

PL. 3 The loop in its four steps. It closes itself and reinforces itself on each turn. There is a single point with a way out, and it lies between the first and the second.

THE FOUR STEPS

- 1 The stimulus. Something happens: a remark, an email, a face, a memory. It lasts a fraction of a second and is almost never registered.
- 2 The reaction. The body responds: something tightens, the breathing changes, the voice rises. It happens before any thought and it is the first thing you can learn to notice.
- 3 The justification. A story appears that explains the reaction and finds it right. It is extremely fast, it is convincing, and it is the part hardest to recognise as part of the loop rather than as a thought of your own.
- 4 The confirmation. The conclusion: «I am like this». The reaction gets built into the identity, and next time it will start with more force because now it has a precedent.

WHY IT REINFORCES ITSELF

Because each turn adds a piece of evidence. A pattern that has been justified forty times has forty reasons in its favour, and on the forty-first it comes out sooner and stronger. None of this requires ill will: it is ordinary learning working on material we would rather not learn.

THE PAUSE

Between the stimulus and the reaction there is an interval, and it is the only place in the loop where there is anything to choose. Once the reaction has happened, the justification comes on its own and the confirmation behind it; arguing with the justification when you have

already reacted is arriving late for everything. The whole practice consists of widening that interval, and it is widened by a single procedure: noticing the bodily reaction before the story arrives.

- 1 Learn first to recognise YOUR characteristic physical reaction. Each person has one or two: jaw, stomach, shoulders, high breathing, heat in the face. Look for it for a week without trying to change anything.
- 2 When you recognise it in the heat of the moment, do nothing with it. Just name it inwardly, with no pretty words: «jaw».
- 3 Take one breath, a full one, before speaking. One. It is not a relaxation technique: it is a deliberate delay.
- 4 Then answer however you like. The practice does not consist in not reacting; it consists in there being someone present when it happens.

WHAT THE PAUSE IS NOT

It is not swallowing things. Repressing a reaction is another reaction, and it usually costs more. The pause does not necessarily change what you are going to say: it changes who says it. Sometimes you will say exactly the same thing, and it will be different because you will have chosen it.

NAMING

The simplest tool in the book and one of the best-performing: putting a name, inwardly and at the time, to what is happening.

THE TECHNIQUE

When a state appears, you put a word to it. One word only, short and descriptive: «fear», «hurry», «rage», «shame», «hunger», «sleep». Not a sentence, not an explanation, not an appraisal. Just the label.

WHY IT WORKS

- It separates. The moment you name something, you stop being only that: someone is needed to do the naming. That someone is what self-observation trains, and naming is the most economical way of summoning it.
- It reduces the intensity. A state named precisely usually drops in volume, and not because it resolves: because it stops being a diffuse mass and becomes a thing with an outline.
- It makes recording possible. Only what has a name can be written down, and only what is written down can be compared with last week's.
- It corrects the error of precision. Most of us use three words for twenty different states. Widening the inner vocabulary is, literally, seeing

more.

PRECISION MATTERS

There is a considerable practical difference between «I feel bad» and «I am tired and on top of that I took offence». The first allows you to do nothing; the second suggests two different things, one of which is fixed by sleeping. A good part of inner confusion is imprecision of vocabulary, and it is corrected with the same discipline as any imprecision: by using the exact word.

FOUR PAIRS WORTH TELLING APART

TIREDDNESS AND DISCOURAGEMENT	The first is fixed by sleeping. The second is not, and confusing them means both get handled badly.
FEAR AND PRUDENCE	Fear anticipates what has not happened; prudence calculates what may happen. One paralyses and the other prepares.
ANGER AND OFFENCE	Anger responds to a limit crossed; offence, to the image you hold of yourself. They feel very alike from the inside and they ask for different things.
GUILT AND SHAME	Guilt says «I did something bad»; shame says «I am something bad». The first is usable; the second almost never is.

THE MISTAKE IN NAMING

Turning it into a speech. As soon as the label grows —«I am feeling a certain irritation probably related to yesterday»— you are back in the intellectual centre and back to being absent. One word. Two at most. Brevity is the technique.

CHAPTER 8

THE RULE OF OBSERVATION

A single rule, and three mistakes that cancel it. This is the shortest chapter and the one to reread most often.

THE RULE

Observe without intervening.

**Look at what is there, as it is,
without changing it, judging it or explaining it.**

WHY YOU DO NOT INTERVENE

For two reasons. The first is technical: the moment you try to change what you are observing, you stop seeing it — the intervention consumes the attention that was doing the looking. The second is deeper: you cannot change with judgement something you do not yet know, and the hurry to correct is what has people spending years fixing the wrong problem.

This does not mean resignation. It means order: first see, and for a good while; then, if necessary, act. In practice something curious and much reported also happens: part of what is observed consistently changes without anything being done, simply because ceasing to be automatic is already a change.

THE THREE MISTAKES

- 1 Judging. «The same thing again, what a disaster I am.» The moment judgement appears, the observation has ended and something else has begun —usually the loop of chapter 6. When you notice the judgement, name that too: «judgement». And carry on.
- 2 Explaining. «This happens to me because as a child...» It may well be true and it is not the moment. Explanation replaces the datum with a theory, and a theory is far more comfortable to look at than a fact.
- 3 Fixing. «From now on I am going to...» Resolutions made in the heat of the moment are almost all false, and their real function is to close the observation before it becomes uncomfortable. Write down what you saw; resolutions are made cold and in writing.

AND THE MISTAKE THAT CONTAINS THEM ALL

Wanting the observation to be good for something today. It is, but on the scale of months. Anyone who demands immediate returns ends up manufacturing findings in order to feel they are progressing, and that ruins the instrument: an observer who wants to find something always finds what they want.

CHAPTER 9

THE SIX RECOLLECTIONS OF THE DAY

Self-observation is not practised all day: that is not possible and anyone who tries gives up within a week. It is practised at specific moments, few and fixed, and it spreads out from there.



THE SAME HOURS EVERY DAY · THIRTY SECONDS EACH

PL. 4 The six moments spread through the day, always the same ones and always at the same hour. In grey, the stretch of rest.

THE SIX MOMENTS

ONE EVERY FEW HOURS

ON WAKING	Before getting up and before picking up the phone. Thirty seconds: what state there is, how the body is, what is the first thing that appears in your head.
BEFORE YOU START	Before the first real task of the day. Posture and breathing, and one word for the state.
BEFORE EATING	The best of the six, because hunger and hurry make a great deal visible. Three breaths before the first mouthful.
MID-AFTERNOON	The moment of the slump, and therefore the most informative. Tell tiredness from discouragement.
ON FINISHING	As the working day closes. What is still switched on: that is what will go home with you if nobody looks at it.
BEFORE SLEEPING	It links up with the nightly inventory of chapter 14.

WHAT IS DONE AT EACH ONE

- 1 Stop. Literally: stop moving for a few seconds.
- 2 Feel the whole body at once —weight, support, posture— without going through it part by part.
- 3 Notice the breathing as it is. Without correcting it. This is the point almost everyone skips.
- 4 Put one word to the state.

5 Carry on with what you were doing. With no conclusions.

Thirty seconds each. Three minutes a day in all. It is deliberately little: what is wanted in the first months is not quantity, it is that the habit should exist.

HOW TO REMEMBER

At first you will not remember, and it is not a problem of will: being absent is precisely the state that prevents you from remembering to look. Use external anchors without any embarrassment: an alarm, a sticker on the door frame, the act of washing your hands. Over the weeks the anchor becomes unnecessary; at the start it is indispensable.

CHAPTER 10

THE RECORD

Marcus Aurelius wrote the «Meditations» with no intention of publishing them: they are the notes of a man observing himself in writing over years. It is the best surviving example of what this chapter asks for, and it is no coincidence that it is also the text that has best withstood eighteen centuries.

WHY IN WRITING AND NOT IN YOUR HEAD

- Because memory for inner states rewrites. Without a record, after ten days you remember the version that suits you.
- Because writing forces you to be specific. A diffuse state cannot be put into one line, and the effort of putting it into one line is half the work.
- Because only what is written can be compared. The notebook's value is not in today's entry: it is in rereading three months together and seeing the pattern no individual entry showed.
- Because paper does not argue. It is the only place where you can be completely sincere with no consequences, and that is a rare possibility.

WHAT GETS WRITTEN DOWN

MINIMUM DAILY ENTRY

DATE	And the time at which you write
THE SIX RECOLLECTIONS	How many of the six you did. The number, with no excuses beside it
STATES OF THE DAY	Two or three words. Only the labels
ONE OBSERVED REACTION	What set it off and where in the body you noticed it. One line
WHAT I DO NOT WANT TO WRITE	The most useful field of the five. It is left blank many days, and the days it gets filled in are worth the whole week

AGAINST THE LITERARY DIARY

The temptation to write well ruins the record. Useful entries are short, ugly and precise. «12/04, 4 of 6, hurry and sleepiness, stomach tightened on reading M.'s message.» That, a hundred times over, reveals more than any elegant page — and it also lasts, which is the other advantage of writing little.

THE REVIEW, WHERE THE VALUE LIES

- 1 Every Sunday: reread the week. Ten minutes. Count the recollections done and look for which day failed and why.
- 2 Every month: reread the month and write five lines. Which state repeats, which trigger repeats, what you have stopped writing down.

- 3 Every three months: reread the quarter and write half a page. This is where what no single week shows appears.
- 4 Every year: reread the year. It is the most uncomfortable practice in the book and the one that teaches most. Set an afternoon aside.

CHAPTER 11

MEASURED BREATHING

Breathing is the only process that runs by itself and can also be governed at will, and that makes it the most practical door into the state of the body. Two patterns are enough for everything this book proposes.



PL. 5 The two patterns, with the relative duration of each stretch. You count at one beat per second, without forcing.

WHY IT WORKS

By a well-established mechanism with nothing mysterious about it: making the out-breath longer than the in-breath shifts the balance of the autonomic nervous system towards the side that lowers the pulse. No

exotic technique is needed; what is needed is for the exhalation to be longer than the inhalation and for it to be counted.

PATTERN FOR COMING DOWN · 4-7-8

- 1** Breathe in through the nose to a count of four, filling the abdomen first.
- 2** Hold to a count of seven. Without tightening the throat or raising the shoulders.
- 3** Breathe out through the mouth, lips slightly parted, to a count of eight.
- 4** Four cycles. No more at first: with eight in a row many people get dizzy, and the dizziness is not a state, it is hyperventilation.

PATTERN FOR HOLDING STEADY · 4-4-4-4

- 1** Breathe in four. Hold four. Breathe out four. Stay empty four.
- 2** The fourth stretch —the empty one— is the one almost everyone skips and the one that does the work: keeping the lungs empty without urgency is what trains tolerance of discomfort.
- 3** Four to six cycles. It serves before a task that requires concentration and before a difficult conversation.

A SPECIFIC WARNING, NOT A FORMALITY

If tingling appears in the hands or around the mouth, or dizziness, or a sense of unreality, stop and breathe normally: those are signs of hyperventilation. Do not practise breath holds if you are pregnant, have epilepsy, uncontrolled high blood pressure, a panic disorder or heart problems, without consulting your doctor first. Never practise breath holds in water.

WHERE IT FITS

In the six recollections of the day no pattern is used: there you only look at the breathing as it is. The patterns are used in three places: in the pause of chapter 6, before a conversation you expect to be difficult, and in the five minutes before the nightly inventory. Outside those three, once a day as training and that is all.

THE BODY AS ANCHOR

Of the three centres, the moving one is the only one always available. It never switches off, it is never somewhere else and it does not have to be summoned. That makes it the most reliable point of entry into observation, and the only one that works even when everything else is in turmoil.

THE FOUR SIGNALS YOU CAN ALWAYS CONSULT

A FOUR-POINT INVENTORY

WEIGHT	Where your body is resting right now. It is the question that returns you to the room fastest.
BREATHING	High or low, short or long, through the nose or the mouth. Without correcting it.
THE POINTS OF TENSION	Jaw, shoulders, brow, hands, stomach. Almost everyone has two favourites and it is worth knowing which.
TEMPERATURE	Cold or heat, and where. It is the least used and it gives away many states before the other three do.

POSTURE, WHICH IS NOT A DETAIL

There is a two-way relationship between posture and state: the state modifies the posture, and the posture modifies the state. That makes

posture useful for two different things. As observation, it is a reliable report on what state you are in. As intervention—the only one this book recommends making in the heat of the moment—it is the fastest lever available: straightening up, dropping the shoulders and releasing the jaw changes something within seconds.

THE EXCEPTION TO THE RULE OF NOT INTERVENING

Chapter 8 says observe without intervening, and here an explicit exception is made for posture and breathing. The reason is practical: they are the only two things that can be corrected without ceasing to observe, because the correction itself is observable. Everything else—thoughts, emotions, decisions—is looked at and left alone.

THE EXERCISE OF THE THREE SUPPORTS

- 1 Sitting or standing, locate three points where your body is resting. Soles of the feet, sitting bones, back against the chair, forearms on the table: whichever they are.
- 2 Feel all three at once. Not one after another: all three at the same time, which is the hard part.
- 3 Add the breathing without letting go of the three supports. Now there are four simultaneous things.
- 4 Hold it for thirty seconds. When it collapses—it will—start again without comment.

This exercise is the most economical way I know of training divided attention, because it requires no conditions at all: it can be done in a meeting, in a queue or in the middle of an argument, and nobody notices.

THE FOUR DIFFICULT ONES

Fear, anger, sadness and shame. They are the four emotions the tradition calls negative and that this book prefers to call difficult, because «negative» suggests they should not be there and that is exactly the mistake to be avoided.

FEAR

IN THE BODY

Tight chest, high breathing

WHAT IT IS FOR

It warns of a risk

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Anticipating what has not happened

ANGER

IN THE BODY

Jaw, fists, heat in the face

WHAT IT IS FOR

It warns of a limit crossed

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Turning into a judgement on someone

SADNESS

IN THE BODY

Weight, throat, wanting to withdraw

WHAT IT IS FOR

It warns of a loss

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Turning into a story about oneself

SHAME

IN THE BODY

Heat, wanting to disappear

WHAT IT IS FOR

It warns of a rule of one's own

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Spreading from an act to the identity

NEITHER EXPRESS THEM NOR REPRESS THEM · WATCH THEM UNTIL THEY PASS

PL. 6 The four, with their bodily signature, the information they bring and the point at which they go wrong.

THE THREE-PART RULE

With all four you do the same thing, and it is three things that have to be held together because each one alone fails.

- 1 Not expressing them automatically. Discharging an emotion onto someone does not discharge it: it trains it. Rage expressed without a filter comes out more easily next time, and breaks things along the way.
- 2 Not repressing them. Pushing an emotion down consumes energy, does not eliminate it and tends to reappear elsewhere —the body, sleep, the way you treat someone who was not at fault.
- 3 Watching them until they pass. This is the third way and the hard one: feeling the whole emotion, in the body, with its name on it, without acting it out and without pushing it away. And waiting. They all pass, and they pass considerably sooner than you think when they are not fed with story.

THE INFORMATION THEY BRING

None of the four is a fault in the system. All four report something and the problem is never that they appear: it is what gets done with them.

WHAT EACH ONE WARNS OF AND WHERE IT GOES WRONG

FEAR	It warns of a risk. It goes wrong when it anticipates what has not happened and settles down to live there.
ANGER	It warns of a limit crossed. It goes wrong when it turns into a judgement on a person instead of on a fact.
SADNESS	It warns of a loss and asks for time. It goes wrong when it turns into a story about oneself: from «I have lost something» to «I am someone who loses».
SHAME	It warns of a rule of your own that has been crossed. It goes wrong —and it is the one that goes wrong worst— when it moves from the act to the identity.

TIMING IT

An observation that surprises almost everyone who makes it for the first time: time how long a difficult emotion lasts when you do not feed it with thought. The bodily wave —the heat, the tightening, the acceleration— usually lasts between one and three minutes. What lasts hours or days is not the emotion: it is the story that switches it back on every time it goes out. And the story is optional, even though it does not look it.

WHEN THIS IS NOT ENOUGH

If a difficult emotion does not come down over several days, if it interferes with sleeping or eating, if it appears with no recognisable trigger or if it brings thoughts of harming yourself, this book is not the tool and self-observation is not going to solve it. That is something you seek help for, and seeking it is a decision made by someone who knows themselves well, not a surrender.

THE NIGHTLY INVENTORY

Seneca describes in his letters a practice he carried out every night: going back over the whole day asking himself what he had done and what he had put right, «like a man going over the accounts». It is probably the best documented exercise in self-knowledge from antiquity and it works exactly the same today.

HOW IT IS DONE

- 1** In bed, with the light off, or sitting for five minutes before you go to bed. Not on the sofa and not with the phone nearby.
- 2** Go back through the day from waking, in order, without skipping. Do not summarise it: go through it. That going through is half the exercise, because most of the day is not in your memory and has to be gone and fetched.
- 3** At each moment where there was a reaction, stop for a second. Do not judge it: locate it. What happened, what you did, where you felt it.
- 4** Choose one single thing you would do differently tomorrow. One. And leave it there, with no solemn resolution.
- 5** Always finish with one thing from the day that went well. Not out of optimism: because an inventory that only collects failures stops being done within two weeks.

WHY THE ORDER MATTERS

Going through the day in chronological order, and not by topic, is what makes what is not remembered appear. When you review by topic you remember what you already knew; when you go through in order, gaps appear —«what did I do between eleven and one?»— and those gaps are the most honest datum the exercise produces. How much life is not in memory is the first thing this practice teaches, and it is a lesson that does not get forgotten.

THE MISTAKE OF TURNING IT INTO JUDGEMENT

Seneca describes it as going over the accounts, not as passing sentence, and the difference is everything. An inventory that turns into reproach produces insomnia and abandonment. If you notice you are judging, go back to the descriptive mode: what happened, what I did, where I felt it. The facts first; the appraisal, if it is needed, in the notebook and in the morning.

IF YOU FALL ASLEEP

You will fall asleep, especially at first, and it does not matter: the part of the run-through done up to that point has already worked. It is in fact one of the best side effects of the practice — many people discover that they fall asleep sooner doing the inventory than going round and round the same thing with no structure.

WHAT DEPENDS ON ME

E pictetus's «Handbook» begins with a distinction, and it is the most useful idea in all of Western practical philosophy: there are things that depend on us and things that do not, and almost all avoidable suffering comes from treating the one as though it were the other.

THE SHORT LIST

WHAT DOES DEPEND ON ME

MY JUDGEMENT	What I decide to think about what happens. Not the first reaction, which is automatic: what I do with it afterwards.
MY ATTENTION	Where I put it and how long I hold it there. It is the only truly own resource.
MY ACTION	What I do, including doing nothing.
MY WORD	What I say and how I say it. Also what I do not say.
MY EFFORT	How much I put in. Never the result; only what I put in.

WHAT DOES NOT DEPEND ON ME

THE PAST	The whole of it and without exception.
WHAT OTHERS DO	Their decisions, their character, their pace, their mood.
WHAT OTHERS THINK OF ME	Not even with all the information in their hands.
THE RESULT	It can be influenced, never determined.
THE BODY, TO A LARGE EXTENT	It is looked after, it is trained, and it still ages and falls ill.
THE FIRST REACTION	It appears before any decision. What comes afterwards is yours.

WHAT THE DISTINCTION DOES NOT MEAN

- It does not mean resignation. Epictetus does not say do not act: he says act on what you can and do not suffer over what you cannot. It is an allocation of effort, not a renunciation.
- It does not mean detachment from people. That other people's decisions do not depend on you does not make them a matter of indifference; it makes them non-negotiable by way of anger.
- It does not mean the result does not matter. It means the result is not where the identity is placed. You work to obtain it and it does not become the measure of yourself.
- It does not mean emotions are forbidden. It means that the emotion is information about you, and not a bill that falls to someone else to pay.

THE EXERCISE OF THE TWO COLUMNS

- 1 Take whatever is weighing on you most right now. One single thing.
- 2 Divide a sheet into two columns: what depends on me, what does not.
- 3 Distribute every element of the matter. All of them, the uncomfortable ones included.
- 4 Cross out the right-hand column. Literally: draw a line through it.
- 5 From the left-hand column, choose the first item and do it today. It is usually far smaller than it looked from inside the problem.

WHY THIS EXERCISE WORKS

Because most of a problem's weight is in the right-hand column, and the right-hand column allows no work: it allows only rumination. Separating the two resolves nothing in itself, and yet it changes the feeling a good deal — because the exhaustion was not coming from the problem, it was coming from pushing against what does not move.

CHAPTER 16

THE ROLES

After a few weeks of observation a finding appears that tends to be uncomfortable: there is not one single person in there. There are several ways of being that take turns according to the context, with a different voice, a different vocabulary and sometimes opinions incompatible with one another.

HOW THEY ARE DETECTED

By the voice, which is the most reliable indicator. Record yourself talking to your boss and to your best friend on the same day: the tone changes, the speed changes, the register of vocabulary changes. By the posture, which also changes. And by the opinions: almost everyone holds, in different contexts, things that do not fit together, and does not notice because the two are never in the same room.

THE COMMONEST ROLES

THE COMPETENT ONE

At work. It cannot admit to not knowing. It is usually the most developed and the most exhausting to sustain.

THE CHILD

With the family you came from. It recovers reactions from twenty years ago all at once, with a fidelity that is frightening.

THE AGREEABLE ONE

With strangers and in groups. It gives way on things it did not want to give way on and finds out afterwards.

THE CRITIC

Alone and on the inside. It is the one that talks when there is nobody there and the one that treats its listener worst.

THE PARTNER

The blindest of them all, because the other person usually sees far more of it than you do.

WHAT IS DONE WITH THIS

Nothing, at first. You observe and you write down which one is in charge: it is the most useful piece of data the notebook can hold, because it explains at a stroke reactions that made no sense in isolation. «The competent one was there» clarifies more than any analysis of why you went on the defensive in that meeting.

In time the second part appears, and it is what the tradition calls self-remembering: noticing that there is something that stays while the roles take turns. It is not a mystical experience and there is nothing spectacular about it; it is the fairly sober sensation of being present in several contexts as the same person. It appears on its own, after months, and it cannot be forced.

THE MISUNDERSTANDING TO AVOID

Discovering that there are several roles does not mean there is an authentic role hidden underneath and the rest are masks. That idea is attractive and does not survive observation: all five are equally real and all of them are you. What is sought is not to find the true one, it is to stop being asleep inside each of them.

UNSETTLED ACCOUNTS

Marcus Aurelius returns again and again, in his notes, to the same matter: the people who annoy him and the time he spends being annoyed. That an emperor with absolute power devoted so many pages to it says a good deal about how universal the problem is.

WHAT AN UNSETTLED ACCOUNT IS

An unclosed matter with someone that goes on consuming attention. A conversation that never took place, a grievance that was never voiced, a reproach repeated mentally in the same words. It is recognised by an unmistakable sign: the imaginary conversation. When you find yourself arguing with someone who is not in the room, you have located an unsettled account.

WHY THEY ARE EXPENSIVE

- They consume attention in the background all day, and attention is precisely the resource this practice sets out to free up.
- They get rehearsed, and in being rehearsed they get sharper: today's version of the grievance is more polished and more unfair than the one from a year ago.
- They spread to people who have nothing to do with it. The way you treat those close to you gets worse because of accounts left open with

others.

- They get confused with identity. A resentment held for long enough ends up looking like a trait of character.

THE INVENTORY OF ACCOUNTS

- 1 Make the list. Everyone with whom you hold imaginary conversations. Without filtering, without justifying and without sorting by seriousness.
- 2 Beside each one, write in a single line what you wanted and did not get. That is the real account, and it very rarely coincides with what you thought the problem was.
- 3 Sort each one into three: it can be talked about, it cannot be talked about, or I do not want to talk about it. All three are legitimate answers.
- 4 The ones that can be talked about: talk, and do it for the sake of the account and not for the sake of being right. The aim is to close, not to win.
- 5 The ones you cannot or do not want to: write them out in full in the notebook, in the second person, with no restraint whatsoever. And do not send them. The addressee of that text is you.

ON FORGIVENESS

This book is not going to ask you to forgive anyone. Forgiveness, when it comes, comes on its own and cannot be manufactured by decision; trying usually produces a false version that covers the matter without closing it. What you can do is stop paying interest: acknowledge the account, write it out in full and stop rehearsing it. In a good many cases that is enough — and in the ones where it is not, at least it stops growing.

UNNECESSARY SUFFERING

A distinction that saves a great deal, and that can be checked in your own experience within a week. There are two layers in almost any distress: what has happened and what you add to it.

THE TWO LAYERS

AN EXAMPLE, ANY EXAMPLE

THE FACT	Your proposal has been turned down.
FIRST LAYER	Disappointment. It lasts a while, it is proportionate, it requires no technique: it is what you feel when something goes wrong.
SECOND LAYER	«The same thing always happens to me. I am no good at this. They are going to realise I do not know. I should have done something else.» It lasts days, it is not proportionate, and it is the one that does the damage.
THE DIFFERENCE	The first layer is put there by the fact. The second you put there yourself, and only the second is optional.

HOW THEY ARE SEPARATED

- 1 When something hurts, write the fact in a single sentence, with no adjectives and no consequences. «The proposal was turned down.» Nothing else.

- 2 Underneath, write everything else: what it means, what it foretells, what it says about you. All of it, unfiltered.
- 3 Read the two parts one after the other. The disproportion between the first line and the rest is the finding of the exercise, and it is usually comic.
- 4 Keep the first line. What is below is not information about the world: it is information about your second layer, which is also useful, but for something else.

THE SECOND LAYER HAS RECOGNISABLE SHAPES

- Generalisation: from «this went wrong» to «it always goes wrong».
- Anticipation: counting as already happened what is merely possible.
- Identification: from «I have done something badly» to «I am someone who does things badly». It is the most expensive of them all.
- Comparison: measuring the fact against the imaginary version of another person to whom it does not happen.
- Retrospective obligation: «I should have», which is demanding that someone who did not have today's information should have acted on today's information.

WHAT THIS CHAPTER DOES NOT SAY

It does not say that pain is optional or that suffering is a mistake. The first layer is legitimate in its entirety, and a real loss hurts for as long as it hurts and there is no technique that shortens it, nor should there be. What is examined here is only the second: the part that is added, rehearsed and prolonged. Confusing the two —and dismissing legitimate pain as though it were an error of thinking— is the worst possible version of this practice.

SINCERITY WITH ONESELF

It is the condition of everything above and the point at which this practice is won or lost. An observer who lies to themselves does not obtain information: they obtain confirmation of what they already believed.

THE HABITUAL LIES

FIVE THAT ALMOST EVERYONE TELLS

«IT DID NOT AFFECT ME»	It is said immediately after something affected you. The speed of the sentence is the proof.
«I DID IT FOR YOU»	There was almost always a motive of your own you did not want to look at. There may be generosity too; rarely only that.
«I HAVE NO TIME»	In most cases it means it is not a priority, which is legitimate and sounds worse.
«I KNOW THAT ALREADY»	Said of something known intellectually and not done. Knowing without doing is not knowing: it is being informed.
«I AM FINE»	The automatic answer par excellence. It is said before having looked.

WHY WE LIE INWARDS

Because it protects. Each of those sentences avoids an uncomfortable fact, and avoiding it is functional in the short term. The

problem is not a moral one: it is technical. A measuring instrument calibrated to give the result you want is no use for measuring, and this whole practice is a measuring instrument.

THE THREE CALIBRATION QUESTIONS

- 1 What is it that I do not want to write in the notebook today? It is the most useful field of the record and the one most often left blank.
- 2 What am I complaining about repeatedly without doing anything? A complaint sustained without action usually points to a decision one does not want to make.
- 3 What would someone who knows me well and is not afraid of me say about me? And if there is nobody like that, that is a fact too.

THE MEASURE OF SINCERITY

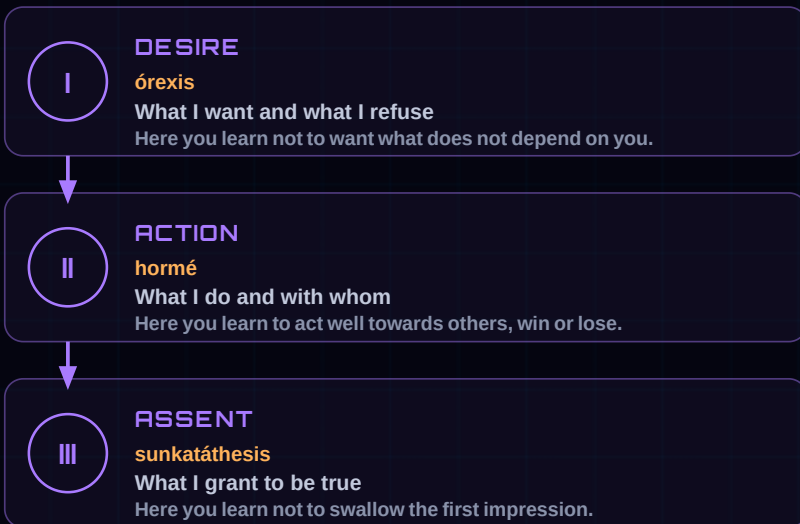
There is a fairly reliable indicator, and it is this: when self-observation is being done sincerely, it is uncomfortable. Not always and not all the time, but regularly. A practice that produces only pleasant sensations and flattering confirmations has turned into something else—usually a pastime with a spiritual vocabulary—and it should be treated with suspicion.

AND THE BALANCE, WHICH ALSO MATTERS

Sincerity is not harshness. The observer who treats themselves as a prosecutor obtains as little information as the one who treats themselves as a defence lawyer: in both cases the fact is buried under the judgement. The right tone is that of someone looking at something with genuine interest and with nothing to defend. It is hard, and it can be learnt.

THE THREE DISCIPLINES

Epictetus did not teach a list of tips. He had a structure, he repeated it constantly, and it is the first thing lost when he is quoted in isolated sentences. They are three fields of training, in an order that is not interchangeable.



IN THIS ORDER · YOU DO NOT MOVE ON WITHOUT THE ONE BEFORE

PL. 7 The three fields with their Greek term. The order matters: each one rests on the one before.

FIRST · DESIRE

The field of what I want and what I refuse. It is where the distinction of chapter 15 applies: learning not to want what does not depend on me, and not to refuse what is going to happen anyway. Epictetus puts it first for a very clear practical reason — as long as desire is set on what you do not control, everything else is impossible, because you live in a state of permanent protest.

It is also the hardest of the three and the one that produces the commonest misunderstanding: it is not about ceasing to want things. It is about ceasing to make your own state conditional on their happening.

SECOND · ACTION

The field of what I do and how I behave towards others. Everything we would today call practical ethics comes in here: keeping your word, treating well those who depend on you, doing the work that falls to you. And it comes in with a condition that is what makes it robust: it is done well regardless of the result and regardless of whether the other person reciprocates.

It comes second because until desire is in order, conduct towards others is an instrument of negotiation: you treat well whoever can give you something. Once the first field is in order, conduct stops being transactional.

THIRD · ASSENT

The finest field and the one that most resembles what this whole book practises: which impressions I grant to be right. Before anything that happens an impression appears—an automatic reading, a «this is bad», a «I am being disrespected»—and there is an instant, a very brief one, in which assent is granted or not.

That instant is exactly the pause of chapter 6. That Epictetus placed it third, as an advanced discipline, is a useful warning: examining impressions is fine work that requires desire to be already fairly well ordered. Anyone who starts here ends up examining impressions in order to be right, which is the opposite use.

THE THREE FIELDS, ONE LINE EACH

DESIRE · ÓREXIS

Not wanting what does not depend on me

ACTION · HORMÉ

Doing well what falls to me, whatever happens

ASSENT · SUNKATÁTHESIS

Not taking the first impression for granted

THE USE OF KNOWING WHICH FIELD YOU ARE IN

When a difficulty resists, it is almost always because you are working in the wrong field. If someone's behaviour drives you to despair, it is not a problem of assent: it is one of desire, because you are wanting that person to be different. If you struggle to keep your promises, it is not desire: it is action. Locating the field saves months.

THE MAP OF THE MANUAL

E pictetus's «Handbook» —Enchiridion, «what is carried in the hand»— is fifty-three very short chapters that his pupil Arrian extracted from the classes. It fits into twenty pages, it has always been in the public domain and it remains the best practical manual there is. What follows is a map so you can go straight to what you need, with the content of each stretch put in my words and not in his.

CHAPTERS 1 TO 10 · THE FOUNDATIONS

1	The distinction between what depends on us and what does not. It is the chapter everything else comes out of and the only indispensable one.
2	What to do with desire and refusal once the distinction has been made.
3	The uncomfortable reminder: everything you love is on loan. It is not pessimism, it is stocktaking.
4	Anticipating the obstacle before starting anything, so that when it arrives it does not throw you.
5	«It is not things that disturb us, but our opinions about them.» The most quoted sentence in the book and the most ill-treated.
6–7	Not boasting of what is not yours. And the image of the ship: you go ashore to pick up shells, and you come back when you are called.
8–10	Wanting things to be as they are. And the question of what capacity you have available for each difficulty.

CHAPTERS 11 TO 29 · THE PRACTICE

11	Nothing is lost: it is given back. Change the verb and the experience changes.
12–13	The price of tranquillity, and why it is worth looking clumsy for a while while you learn.
14–18	Not demanding that others be otherwise. And the warning against superstition, which in Epictetus is explicit.
17	You are an actor in a play whose part you did not choose. What you do choose is to play it well.
20–21	Nobody offends you: it is you who accepts the offence. And keeping death in view, not in order to be anguished but in order to sort out priorities.
22–25	What the discipline costs in reputation and in company. It is the most honest stretch of the book and the least quoted.
26–29	Applying to your own affairs the standard you apply to other people's. And chapter 29, the longest: do not begin anything without having looked at the whole price.

CHAPTERS 30 TO 53 · DEALINGS WITH OTHERS, AND THE CLOSE

30–33	Duties according to the role you occupy. And 33, which is a complete code of conduct: speak little, do not swear oaths, avoid spectacle, eat with measure.
34–36	On pleasure: examine it before and after. It is the stretch that most resembles what we would today call work with impulses.
37–41	Not accepting a role too big for you. And not devoting more time to the body than is necessary, which in Epictetus is a warning against vanity and not against care.
42–45	When someone treats you badly, they are acting according to what seems right to them. And do not judge by what you see: you do not have the facts.
46–48	Do not talk about philosophy: practise it and let it show in your acts. The most useful warning for anyone who reads books like this one.
49–53	What matters is not interpreting the texts, it is applying them. And the close, with the four quotations Epictetus asked to be kept always to hand.

HOW TO USE THIS MAP

Do not read the Handbook straight through expecting it to transform you: they are class notes and it shows. Use it the way a manual is used: when you have a specific problem, look for the stretch. If someone drives you to despair, chapters 14 and 42. If you cannot get something started, 29. If you have been offended, 20. If you have vanity to spare, 46. It is in the public domain in any language and in any format: there is no excuse for not having it to hand.

AND A WARNING ABOUT TRANSLATIONS

There are old public-domain translations, made in an English that is hard going today, and modern translations far more readable but in copyright. None of them is neutral: the Stoic vocabulary — prohairesis, hormé, oikeiosis— has no clean equivalent in English and each translator decides. If something sounds odd to you, it is almost always a decision of the translator's and not of Epictetus's.

THE VIEW FROM ABOVE

Que last exercise, documented in Marcus Aurelius and practised by the Stoics as a formal technique. It is the fastest of all those in this book and the one that produces the most abrupt change of perspective.

THE EXERCISE

- 1 Close your eyes and place yourself in the room you are in. With no ornament: the room just as it is.
- 2 Rise. Look at the building from above, with your room inside it and the others around, each with someone doing something.
- 3 Keep rising. The neighbourhood, the whole city, with all the people who at this moment are arguing, sleeping, being born and dying all at once.
- 4 Keep going. The country, the continent, the whole planet seen from outside, with its night and its day at the same time.
- 5 Now add time: the same view a thousand years ago, and a thousand years hence. The same cities under other names and other people doing exactly the same things.
- 6 Come back. Descend to your room and open your eyes. Two minutes in all.

WHAT IT DOES

It reduces the scale of your own affair, and it does so by a route reasoning cannot take. Telling yourself «this is not that important» does not work because it is an assertion and it can be argued with. Seeing the scale does work, because it argues nothing: it only changes the point you look from.

Marcus Aurelius returns to this operation again and again in his notes, and always in the same context: when he is annoyed with someone at his court or overwhelmed by an affair of government. That the most powerful man in the Mediterranean needed to remind himself of the real size of his problems is, probably, the best argument in the exercise's favour.

WHEN TO USE IT

IT WORKS VERY WELL	For the recent offence, the argument that will not leave your head and worry about what others think of you.
IT WORKS SO-SO	For a practical decision that has to be made: reducing the scale does not help you choose.
IT DOES NOT WORK	For a real loss. There, making the matter small is a disrespect to what was lost, and chapter 18 already explained why not all pain is an error of perspective.

THE MISUNDERSTANDING TO AVOID

The view from above does not say that nothing matters. It says that almost nothing matters AS MUCH as it seems from inside, which is a different assertion and a far more defensible one. If the exercise leaves you indifferent to what you ought to attend to, you have overdone it: the aim is to recover proportion, not to lose interest.



And with that the repertoire closes. Six instruments, seven plates, a notebook and a year. There is nothing more, and anyone who practises half of what is proposed here for twelve months will have done more work on themselves than most people do in a whole lifetime.

THE OBSERVER'S BODY

This chapter exists because almost no book on this subject writes it, and because without it the rest does not hold up. Attention is not an abstract faculty: it is a biological function with quite concrete material conditions.

HOW THIS CHAPTER IS FRAMED

What follows are common-sense habits aimed at having attention available. It is not an individualised dietary plan or a training programme, and it does not take account of pathologies. If you have a medical condition, take medication, are pregnant or have a history of an eating disorder, check with your health professional before applying anything from here.

SLEEP, WHICH COMES FIRST AND BY A DISTANCE

There is no attention technique that makes up for sleeping badly. It is the weightiest factor in the whole book and the least attractive, and that is why it gets ignored. An observer on five hours of sleep has no attention to divide: they have a deficit, and what they are going to observe is mostly their own irritability.

- A fixed bedtime, weekends included. Regularity weighs more than the total.
- The last hour with no screen and no work. If you change only one thing from this chapter, change this one.
- The nightly inventory of chapter 14 is a better substitute for the involuntary review carried out with the eyes open at three in the morning.
- A cool, dark room. Cheap and effective.

THE TABLE, IN TERMS OF ATTENTION

The criterion here is not body composition: it is stability. What matters is avoiding the two states that make observing anything impossible, which are drowsiness after eating and the irritability of hunger — and it is worth knowing that the second is confused with moral indignation with astonishing ease.

- Eat slowly and without a screen. It is also the best exercise in divided attention available three times a day.
- Protein and vegetables at the main meal; fast sugar, little of it. The slump afterwards falls right on the mid-afternoon recollection and spoils it.
- Caffeine early and in a fixed amount. It is the substance that most distorts the perception of your own state, and this practice consists in perceiving your own state.
- Alcohol, little of it and never the night before a day that matters. It flattens deep sleep and the effect is charged the next day.

- Before eating outside mealtimes, one written question: what am I hungry for? Emotional hunger is recognised the moment it is asked.

MOVEMENT

The contemplative tradition tends to ignore the body or to distrust it, and in that it is wrong. Daily movement does three things that serve this practice directly: it discharges the activation that otherwise turns into rumination, it improves sleep, and it gives access to clear bodily sensations, which are the material of observation.

- Walk forty minutes a day, and part of that without headphones. Walking in silence is one of the best conditions for observing that exist.
- Some strength work twice a week. Holding an upright posture for hours is a demand on strength, not on good intentions.
- Neck and shoulder mobility daily: they are the two points where almost everyone accumulates the tension they later cannot account for.
- None of this has to be intense. Consistency is the variable, as in everything else in this book.

THE FOUR MATERIAL CONDITIONS OF ATTENTION

SLEEP	Enough of it and regular. It is the first and there is no substitute.
STABLE GLUCOSE	Orderly meals. Attention is metabolically expensive to maintain.
MOVEMENT	Daily and moderate. It discharges what otherwise gets chewed over.
SILENCE	Stretches with no stimulus. It is not a spiritual luxury: it is the condition for hearing anything.

THE SUMMARY

Sleep at the same hour, eat slowly and without a screen, walk every day and set aside some silence. There is nothing mysterious about it, it is ninety per cent of the work, and almost nobody does it — which is also, come to think of it, the summary of this whole book.

THE BEGINNER'S MISTAKES

Predictable, and therefore avoidable.

- 1** Wanting to do it all day. It is impossible, it produces exhaustion within a week and it ends in abandonment with the false conclusion that it cannot be done. Six moments of thirty seconds. That is all, for months.
- 2** Turning observation into judgement. The central mistake: the moment «how badly I do this» appears, the practice has turned into the loop of chapter 6, with a new vocabulary.
- 3** Looking for experiences. Expecting unusual states, lights, sensations of unity. This practice produces none of that and whoever looks for it ends up convincing themselves they have had it. What it produces is more time awake, which is less showy and considerably more useful.
- 4** Reading instead of practising. Ten books and three weeks of notebook. It is the most comfortable mistake and the hardest to recognise, because reading also feels like progress.
- 5** Not writing. Without a record there is no comparison, without comparison there is no correction, and without correction this is repetition, not practice.
- 6** Telling people. Explaining to others what you are doing produces an immediate satisfaction that substitutes for the

satisfaction of the work, and along the way turns the practice into an identity. Do it and do not talk about it.

- 7 Practising in a crisis. Intensive observation is not where an acute crisis gets resolved; at best it does not help. In a crisis you reduce it to the minimum, you look after your sleep and you seek help.

THE REALITY CHECK

There is a very simple way of knowing whether this is working, and it has nothing to do with what is felt during the exercises: ask whoever lives with you whether they find you different, and in what. If you are six months in and nobody has noticed anything in any direction, something is not happening where it ought to be happening.

AND THE REVERSE TEST

If what they notice is that you are odder, more isolated or more severe, the practice is doing harm and it has to be stopped and reviewed. A well-run discipline of attention makes people more present and easier to deal with. Any road that takes you away from your own people and convinces you that this is progress is badly built, and that diagnosis applies to this book just as it does to any other.

THE YEAR OF OBSERVATION

A twelve-month plan and a notebook. With this the book ends.

THE FOUR QUARTERS

MONTHS 1–3	Only two things: the six recollections of the day and the daily notebook entry. Nothing else. It is deliberately little.
MONTHS 4–6	The nightly inventory and the exercise of the three supports are added. Work on the pause begins.
MONTHS 7–9	Epictetus's two columns are added once a week, and the inventory of unsettled accounts, just once.
MONTHS 10–12	Nothing is added. The last quarter sustains what came before, and it is the one that proves whether there is a practice or there was enthusiasm.

THE THREE INDICATORS

- 1** The number. Recollections done against those planned, taken from the notebook. Above seventy per cent there is a practice.
- 2** Recovery. How long you take to come back after dropping it for a week. At first it is weeks; with the habit installed, days. It is the most reliable of the three indicators.

- 3 Outside testimony. What the people who live with you notice, asked directly.



STARTING RECORD

BEFORE YOU START

START DATE

MY SIX HOURS

MY CHARACTERISTIC
PHYSICAL REACTION

THE ROLE I HOLD MOST

WHAT I EXPECT FROM THIS

WHAT I DO NOT WANT TO
LOOK AT

ABOUT THE LAST LINE

Write it. It is the most informative of the six and the one almost nobody fills in. A year from now, rereading it will explain a good deal of what happened in between.

DAILY TEMPLATE

COPY ONE A DAY

DATE _____

RECOLLECTIONS DONE 1 · 2 · 3 · 4 · 5 · 6

STATES OF THE DAY _____

ONE OBSERVED REACTION _____

WHERE I FELT IT IN THE BODY _____

WHAT I DO NOT WANT TO WRITE _____

QUARTERLY REVIEW

EVERY THREE MONTHS

RECOLLECTIONS PLANNED / DONE _____ / _____

THE STATE THAT REPEATS MOST _____

THE TRIGGER THAT REPEATS MOST _____

WHAT I HAVE STOPPED WRITING DOWN _____

WHAT I ADD NEXT QUARTER _____

CLOSING THE YEAR

AT TWELVE MONTHS

ADHERENCE PERCENTAGE _____

TIME TO RECOVER AFTER
AN INTERRUPTION _____

WHAT THE PERSON I LIVE
WITH HAS SAID _____

ONE THING I BELIEVED
ABOUT MYSELF THAT WAS
FALSE _____

WHAT I AM STILL DOING A
YEAR LATER _____



That next-to-last question is the aim of the whole book, and it is worth saying so at the end so that it does not get lost. Self-observation is not practised in order to reach any state, or to obtain calm, or to belong to anything. It is practised in order to find out things you took as certain about yourself and that were not true. Each of those corrections gives back a piece of life that was running on automatic.

And if at the end of the year you have twelve months of notebook in your own hand, one belief less about yourself and the people around you find you a little more present, then this has worked. There is nothing more at the end of the road, and it turns out to be quite a lot.

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